

Lesson 13

Let Life Be The Regulator

When I was at my absolute worst, I joined many programs that had endless content, like 40 hours of material, 60 somatic exercises you can do, interrupt your thoughts 300 times a day, do these six steps every time you feel anything. And I remember thinking like, if this is what it takes me to heal, I am literally screwed because how am I supposed to do all of that and raise my kids?

How was I supposed to interrupt my thoughts all day and also have a business? It felt like healing was going to be a full-time job, like life was going to have to be on hold while I did all of these tools and techniques perfectly and consistently, and it felt like what I was supposed to do instead of living my life, not as I lived my life.

And that is when I realized I needed something different. I needed something that worked with my life, something that did not require me to stop living in order to heal. That's when the idea of letting life be the regulator started to make sense to me for a sensitized nervous system. All these prescriptive tools can often create more problems than they solve.

They become this new thing you need to get right, and another thing that you have to monitor and something else for you to be dependent on, and something you're afraid you're going to miss or mess up or not do the right way. And I see a much deeper issue in this, and that is that when you use a tool, every single time you feel uncomfortable, you are teaching your nervous system, that discomfort is dangerous and needs to be handled with a tool.

You are reinforcing the belief that something is wrong. This may work for a system that's closer to dysregulation, but not for a severely sensitized system. Even well-intentioned practices can just become another form of avoidance. Just one more way to escape what you're feeling. Instead of learning what I'm teaching you in this course, which is that you can handle it, what I'm asking you to do is kind of the exact opposite.

Instead of doing something with every negative emotion or sensation or thought. You do nothing. You let it be there. You respond differently. You stop treating it like a problem to solve. And I knew I didn't wanna spend the rest of my life managing myself. I didn't want my sense of safety to depend on whether or not I did my regulation routine that day.

Let's be real. Nobody wants to rely on tools all day. The whole reason people do these extensive routines is so that they can eventually get back to their life. So what if you didn't need to do all of that before getting back into your life? What if you could do both at the same time? That is what letting life be, the regulator is about.

You need things to do. When you are sensitized, one of the worst things you can do is have nothing to do. I know that sounds counterintuitive because when we feel terrible, we wanna rest, withdraw, and then just wait until we feel better before we take anything else on. But here is what happens when you have nothing to do.

Your attention, your focus, your energy automatically defaults to your symptoms, to your body. Your brain has nowhere else to go. So where is it gonna go? To the pain, to the fear, to the sensations. And as I've taught you again and again, the more attention those circuits get, the stronger they become. You need things that pull your attention, things that engage you, things that give your brain somewhere else to go.

This is not about distraction. This is not about avoiding feeling what you're feeling. This is giving your life some structure and meaning so that your symptoms aren't the main event all day long. When you are truly engaged in something, the pain and symptom circuits in your brain get used to less.

That's what we want. The less you use them, the weaker they get over time, and you don't have to wait until you feel better to start living again. You don't have to wait until all the symptoms are gone. You don't have to wait until you feel ready. You don't have to wait until you feel certain that everything is gonna work out and be okay.

You can start now while you still feel bad. At this point, I wanna make a quick note. About can't versus won't. A lot of people will respond to what I'm talking about right now and say that they can't. They can't do things. They can't go places. They can't just live their life. They can't reenter life. And I wanna be really direct with you here because most of the time can't actually means won't.

This is not like you being dramatic, it's just because underneath the can't. Is a lot of fear. Fear of how you're gonna feel while you're doing it. Fear that something will go wrong, fear that you're going to be miserable all the time. That's not the same as can't. That's choosing not to because of that fear.

I'm obviously not talking about genuine physical limitations if you literally cannot do something that's real. But most of the time what I see is it's not that people can't, it's that they won't because they're afraid of how they're going to feel or what could possibly happen if they do. And this is especially rough because a sensitized brain will always go to the worst case scenario.

It will convince you that the worst possible thing is going to happen, and spoiler alert, you won't be able to handle it. And you have to remind yourself as much as you are able. That is the fear, talking that is not reality. So if you catch yourself saying, I can't, and I want you to ask yourself, is this actually can't or is this won't because I'm scared.

There's no judgment in that. Fear is real, but naming it in an honest way, I believe is like the first step to moving through it and getting to the other side of this, because it's obviously going to be scary to do things that you have believed can't be done. Healing does not happen through tools. It happens through living when you reengage with normal life, when you do the things that you've been avoiding, when you go places, when you connect with people, when you work, when you create.

When you just exist in the world, you're sending a signal to your nervous system. You are showing it. Life is safe. You're not telling it. You're showing it through your behavior, through your response, the language of the nervous system. Your nervous system doesn't learn from what you think or what you tell yourself.

It learns from what you do. And when you do normal life things while feeling horrifically uncomfortable, and you notice that nothing catastrophic happens, your system begins to recalibrate. That is how life becomes the regulator. You're not doing the tools so that you can one day live your life. You living and the living is what desensitizes you, and the living is what will go on to regulate you.

Instead of asking myself, how do I regulate myself today? I started asking, how do I want to live today? What do I wanna experience today? And once I shifted that, everything changed because when you're focused on regulating and desensitizing, your attention stays on the symptoms. You are still in that management mode.

So you're still treating it like a problem to fix, but when you're focused on living, your attention goes somewhere else. It goes to what matters to you, to what you value. To the life that you actually want to have. And when your attention is on a living, instead of fixing those pain and symptom circuits in your brain get used less and they quiet down, you stop feeding them without focus, which is why they quiet down.

You do not need a six step brain rewiring process. Brain rewiring is gonna happen. You don't have to micromanage that. It happens automatically based on what you do, based on what you teach your nervous system. Every time you respond differently, every time you do something normal while feeling uncomfortable, and you don't let that stop you, you're creating new neural pathways.

You're teaching your brain that life isn't dangerous, that you can handle discomfort, and that you don't need to be in constant protection mode. And it needs that signal. It needs that information more than anything else. This is the work. The tools are not the work. The technique is not the work. The living is the work and it's hard work.

The reason I teach it this way is because I needed something that didn't require me to put my life on hold. My life had been on hold for years. I'm a mom. I was working, I was working through all of this. I had a job. I had responsibilities. I had clients. I had children. I had a life I could not spend three hours a day on healing exercises and then try to squeeze my actual life in around the edges of my healing.

I needed healing to happen while I was living, and that's exactly what letting life be. The regulator does. You're not doing separate healing work and then also trying to live. You're living and the living is the healing work. Every time you show up for life while feeling terrible. You're doing the real work every time you do not let your symptoms dictate your schedule for the day.

You're doing the real work. Every single time you respond with less fear to a normal life situation, you're doing the work. It is all integrated. It's not separate. At some point, healing stops being something you do. It becomes something that happens in the background while you live. That is

where this course leads.

It's not to a perfectly regulated nervous system. It's not to a life where you never feel uncomfortable. It leads to a life that does not revolve around managing yourself anymore. You let life be the regulator by actually living it, by showing up, by responding differently and having less fear, and by trusting that your system will recalibrate.

When you stop treating everything like a threat, you don't need more tools, you need more life.